Networking Through Collaborative Reflection on Methods: A Peer Review–World Café for Early Career Researchers (Workshop)

Schlander, Anna
schlander@linglit.tu-darmstadt.de
Technical University of Darmstadt, Germany

Reiche, Ruth
reiche@linglit.tu-darmstadt.de
Technical University of Darmstadt, Germany

Konstanciak, Johanna
konstanciak@uni-trier.de
Trier University

Büttner, Alexandra
alexandra.buettner@adwmainz.de
Academy of Science and Literature Mainz

Deicke, Aline
aline.deicke@adwmainz.de
Academy of Science and Literature Mainz

Rapp, Andrea
rapp@linglit.tu-darmstadt.de
Technical University of Darmstadt, Germany

Lemaire, Marina
marina.lemaire@uni-trier.de
Trier University

Introduction

The data competence centre HERMES – Humanities Education in Research, Data, and Methods – is dedicated to teaching data skills in the humanities and cultural sciences, to further develop them and to critically reflect upon them. Research should not only be conducted in accordance with the principles of good scientific practice and build upon transparent communication when working with data. We follow Drucker in her concept of viewing data in the humanities and cultural studies not as “data”, something given, but as “capta”, something actively chosen or generated (cf. Drucker 2011, 3). In that sense, publishing research findings and the underlying data, along with a detailed description of the methods used for its collection and analysis, becomes increasingly vital. Digital publication formats facilitate this practice by enabling reproducibility and, consequently, verifiability of results. This is also relevant to successfully pass peer review procedures.

At HERMES we train researchers to critically analyse data and data sources and address the emerging communicative and methodological challenges of engaging with digital cultural data by providing a wide range of programmes. For this reason, the establishment of a network for doctoral students working with digital methods is essential. HERMES provides them with opportunities for interdisciplinary exchange and critical reflection on their work within a supportive environment. The half-day workshop is intended to help achieve these goals.

A Peer Review – World Café

Participants will approach the topic of “peer review” through role play in a World Café format inspired by König et al. (2024) who applied it to the topic of research data management. Since peer reviews are a cornerstone of scientific quality assurance, the participants are to become reviewers themselves. They will develop their skills in methodology and scientific communication by changing their perspective.

Motivation and Aim of the World Café

To internalise scientific quality criteria participants take on the role of peer reviewers and learn to focus specifically on individual aspects of the research work. Abstract concepts such as “reproducibility” or “data quality” are, thus, transformed into concrete ideas and requirements for the work. As participants not only focus on their own research work, but also on the work of other participants, the ability to identify and apply robust methodologies while ensuring transparent communication is fostered.

Format and Realisation

Participants will examine various aspects of the other participants' research work at different tables. The research work is discussed in an interview at the respective table. The colleagues sitting at the same table will focus on a specific aspect that is inspired by the requirements that a peer review places on the researchers (see questions below). For example, the researchers at one table are interviewed with focus on the research design. At another table they will discuss whether the presentation of their results is comprehensible.

Target Audience and Number of Participants

The target audience for the workshop is PhD students from the humanities and cultural sciences who are applying digital methods in their work. In order to benefit as much as possible from the workshop, participants should ideally be thinking about publishing their first results.

The World Café is designed for twelve participants and a total of four stations. Four of the twelve participants will become table mentors and will be stationed at one table. The table mentors are preferably doctoral students who according to their strengths and preferences can choose one topic (see list of topics below) for a table. This leaves eight rotating participants, who will move from table to table in four rounds of 20 minutes each. Therefore, apart from the orientation round, there will always be three people sitting at one table: 1x interviewee, 1x reviewer and 1x table mentor. With four rounds and four stations, all rotating participants should take on the role of reviewer twice and the role of interviewee twice.

The exercise is divided into the following components:

Introduction to the World Café (15 min)

The rules of the format are explained. Table mentors and supervisors are selected.

Functionality and Purpose of the Peer Review Process (30 min)

We will explain how peer review works and how it contributes to scientific quality assurance.

Preparation for the Role Play (30 min)

Participants receive a “working sheet” that will accompany them through the various rounds of the World Café. The “working sheet” is used to present their own research project in a structured way and to improve it through the role-played review process.

Orientation Round – Familiarisation with the Role Profile (20 min)

The role profiles prepared by the organisers are supplemented with the ideas and suggestions of the participants. Each team gathers around a table and gets acquainted.

World Café Rounds 1–4 (around 20 min each)

One participant from each table takes on the role of the interviewee. Another table member takes on the role of the reviewer. Table mentors remain seated at one table for the second part of the workshop. Change after 20 minutes.

The following topics and questions will be discussed at the four tables:

- Are the research questions and hypotheses clearly formulated?
- Are the research approach and methodology suitable for the project and is their use convincing and logically justified?
- Are the research results comprehensible and reproducible?
- Are there ethical and/or legal guidelines and requirements that need to be taken into consideration?

Conclusion: Feedback Round (30 min)

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